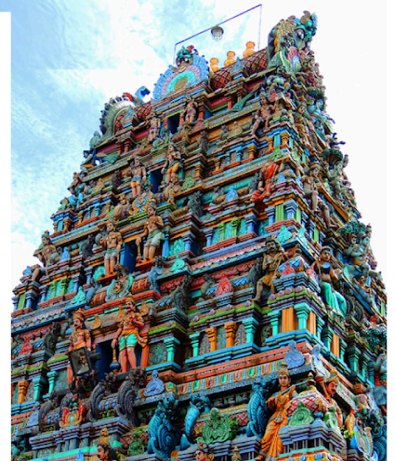


General Knowledge

Art & Culture

STUDY NOTES

Indian Paintings



Indian Paintings

Indian painting is a rich and diverse tradition that spans thousands of years, with styles varying across regions, periods, and cultural influences. The evolution of Indian art can be classified into distinct periods, each reflecting the societal, religious, and political milieu of its time. In the 3rd century AD, Vatsyayana in his book Kamasutra mentioned **six main principles/limbs** or shadanga of paintings. They are:

- **Variety of form** - Rupabheda
- **The portrayal of the likeliness of the subject** - Sadrisyan
- **Creation of lustre and gleam with the colours** - Bhava
- **Mixing of colours to resemble the effects of modelling** - Varnikabhanga
- **Proportion of the object or subject** - Pramanam
- **Immersion of emotions** - Lavanyayoganam

There are numerous references to the art of painting in **Brahmanical and Buddhist literature**, **for example**, the representation of the **myths and lore on textiles is known as Lepya Chitra**.

The play, **Mudrarakshasa by Vishakhadutta**, also mentions the names of various paintings or patas, which are important to understand the different styles of paintings and to observe all the principles of paintings.

Prehistoric Rock Art

- Bhimbetka caves (Madhya Pradesh), Kaimur Hills (Bihar), etc.
- The **earliest known paintings in India are found on rock surfaces**, created by prehistoric humans. These paintings depict animals, human figures, and hunting scenes.
- These paintings are among the earliest expressions of human creativity and offer insight into the lives of early humans.



Bhimbetka Rock Paintings

- It is **located south of Bhopal in the Vidhyan ranges of Madhya Pradesh.**
- The rock shelters have more than 500 rock paintings. It was declared a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2003.
- The oldest paintings are estimated to be 30,000 years old and have survived due to their location deep inside the caves.
- There is marked continuity in occupancy of the caves from 100,000 BC to 1000 AD with many paintings being painted on top of one another.
- The paintings at Bhimbetka belong to Upper Paleolithic, Mesolithic, Chalcolithic, early historic and medieval periods. However, most of the paintings belong to the Mesolithic age.



Prehistoric Rock Art Paintings in India

Rock Art Painting	Located In	Features
Bhimbetka Caves	Madhya Pradesh	Depicts scenes of hunting, dancing, and animal figures.
Cave Paintings of Ajanta	Maharashtra	Buddhist religious themes, deities, and stories of the Jataka tales.
Kaimur Hills	Bihar	Features animal figures, human motifs, and geometric shapes.
Badami Caves	Karnataka	Includes figurative images of gods, animals, and geometric designs.
Eagle's Nest	Arunachal Pradesh	Paintings of animals like elephants, tigers, and hunting scenes.

Pachmarhi Caves	Madhya Pradesh	Depictions of animals, human figures, and hunting scenes.
Rock Shelters of Bhimbetka	Madhya Pradesh	Early hunting scenes, ritualistic motifs, and wild animals.
Tirupati Rock Paintings	Andhra Pradesh	Geometric patterns, animal figures, and human figures.

Mural Paintings:

- Mural paintings began in ancient temples and palaces, primarily depicting religious themes.
 - They were often large-scale works painted directly onto the walls or ceilings.
 - Examples:**
- Ajanta Caves (Maharashtra):** The paintings here are famous for their intricate depictions of the life of Buddha, Buddhist Jataka tales (stories of Buddha's previous lives), and beautiful depictions of divine and royal figures. These paintings, which date from the 2nd century BCE to the 6th century CE, are celebrated for their mastery of expression and vibrant colour.
- Ellora Caves (Maharashtra):** These caves contain a mix of Buddhist, Hindu, and Jain murals. The artwork often represents religious narratives and deities, with the Kailasa temple being one of the highlights.
- Mural paintings also depicted the life of royalty and courtly practices, showing rulers, courtiers, and warriors, their lifestyle, and even their grandeur and attire.





(Ajanta and Ellora Caves (Maharashtra))

Mural Paintings in India

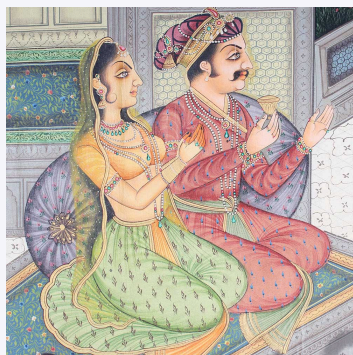
Mural Painting Name	Location	Ruler/Period	Time Period
Dutch Palace Murals	Kochi (Mattancherry), Kerala	Rulers of Kochi (local kings)	16th century CE
Mysore Palace Murals	Mysore, Karnataka	Wadiyar Kings of Mysore	18th to 19th century CE
Tanjore Paintings	Tanjore (Thanjavur), Tamil Nadu	Chola Dynasty	16th century CE
Krishna Museum Murals	Alappuzha, Kerala	Local Kings of Kerala	17th century CE
Bikaner Wall Paintings	Bikaner, Rajasthan	Rao Bika of Bikaner	16th to 17th century CE
Kota Wall Paintings	Kota, Rajasthan	Maharao Madho Singh of Kota	18th century CE

Auroville Murals	Pondicherry	Aurobindo Ashram (Auroville)	20th century CE
Chola Temple Murals	Various Temples in Tamil Nadu	Chola Kings (Rajaraja, Rajendra)	10th to 12th century CE
Kangra School of Painting	Kangra, Himachal Pradesh	Local Rulers of Kangra	18th century CE
Khajuraho Temple Murals	Khajuraho, Madhya Pradesh	Chandela Dynasty	9th to 11th century CE

Miniature Paintings

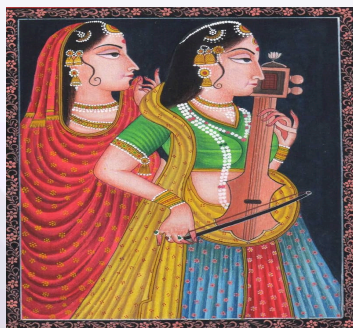
- Miniature paintings in India flourished between the 16th and 19th centuries, with several distinct regional styles that reflected local culture, religion, and royal patronage.

Mughal Miniature



- Period:** 16th to 18th century.
- Known for their **intricate details, vibrant colours**, and a blend of Persian, Indian, and European influences. The style reached its peak during the reign of Emperor Akbar, under whose patronage the Mughal court artists developed a unique form.

Rajput Miniature



- Period: 16th to 19th century, particularly in Rajasthan.
- Known for their bold colours, exquisite details, and decorative borders. The style developed in the courts of Rajasthan and was influenced by local traditions and the artistic tastes of the Rajput rulers.
- Subject matter often included scenes from the **Mahabharata** and **Ramayana**, **courtly life**, **royal portraits**, and **love stories**.

Pahari Miniature

- Period:** 17th to 19th century, from the Himalayan region



(e.g., Jammu, Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, and Punjab Hills).

- Pahari paintings are known for their **delicate** and **romantic** themes. The style reflects the natural beauty of the region, with soft, harmonious colours and fine brushwork.
- The most common themes are religious stories, particularly those focusing on **Krishna's** life and the **Radha-Krishna love stories**.

Folk and Tribal Art

- Folk and Tribal Art forms in India are deeply rooted in tradition, each with its own distinct style and symbolism.

Warli Painting:

- Maharashtra, particularly among the Warli tribes of the North Sahyadri Range.
- Warli paintings are created using white pigment made from rice paste, applied on mud walls, and feature geometric shapes such as circles, triangles, and squares.
- These paintings primarily depict nature, daily life, animals, and human figures in a symbolic and stylized form. Key themes include animals like cows, elephants, and tigers, as well as seasonal activities like harvests and weddings.



Madhubani Art:

- Bihar, particularly the Mithila region.
- Known for its vibrant colours, detailed patterns, and use of natural dyes and pigments, Madhubani art is often done with a brush or fingers. The paintings are typically done on paper, cloth, or walls.
- The paintings reflect religious, mythological, and natural themes, often featuring gods and goddesses, animals, plants, and celestial beings. The art is deeply symbolic and is closely linked to Hindu rituals, festivals, and the community's connection with nature.



Pattachitra:

- Odisha is especially famous in the regions of Puri and Raghurajpur.
- Pattachitra art involves intricate designs painted on cloth, often using natural colours. The art is characterized by a rich tradition of storytelling, with details about Hindu deities, mythological stories, and folk tales.
- Popular themes include depictions of Lord Jagannath, stories from the Ramayana and Mahabharata, and other mythological narratives. The paintings are known for their intricate borders and the fine details in the expressions of the characters.



Folk and Tribal Paintings of India

Folk/Tribal Painting Name	State	Features
Pattachitra Paintings	Odisha, West Bengal	Depict mythological narratives of Hindu deities, intricate borders, and natural dyes .
Kalighat Paintings	West Bengal	Traditional watercolour paintings featuring religious themes , social themes , and portraits .
Sanjhi Art	Uttar Pradesh	Paper-cutting techniques are used to create intricate patterns, often religious in nature.
Phad Paintings	Rajasthan	Depict historical stories and mythological tales on long scrolls of cloth or canvas.
Tanjore Paintings	Tamil Nadu	Famous for gold leaf work , depicting deities with a strong focus on religious themes .
Mina Tribal Paintings	Rajasthan	Geometric patterns and bright colors , often featuring animals , birds , and nature .
Pichwai Paintings	Rajasthan	Depicts Lord Krishna and his divine stories using rich colors and intricate details.
Bhil Art	Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat	Abstract motifs , nature themes , bold colors , and symbolism often representing tribal culture.
Kalamkari Paintings	Andhra Pradesh, Telangana	Fabric painting using natural dyes to depict mythological and religious themes .
Gond Art	Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh	Nature-inspired patterns , bold lines , and vibrant colors , often incorporating animals and plants.

Saura Paintings	Odisha	Geometric and abstract motifs, often connected to ritualistic practices and tribal culture .
Dokra Art	Odisha, West Bengal, Chhattisgarh	Traditional metal casting used to create tribal motifs , animals, and abstract figures .

Regional Schools of Painting

- It refers to the distinct styles of painting that emerged in different regions of India. Each school is characterized by unique features, techniques, and themes influenced by local traditions, culture, and patronage.

School of Painting	Region	Period	Characteristics	Examples
Rajasthani School	Rajasthan	16th–19th centuries	Bright colours, stylized forms, flat perspective, themes of Rajput life, Krishna devotion, and local landscapes.	Kishangarh Radha-Krishna, Mewar's court scenes, Bundi's hunting scenes.
Pahari School	Himachal Pradesh, Punjab Hills	17th–19th centuries	Delicate detailing, natural landscapes, spiritual themes, romantic depictions of Radha and Krishna.	Kangra's Gita Govinda, Basholi's bold compositions.
Mughal School	Delhi, Agra, Lahore	16th–18th centuries	Persian-inspired miniature style, detailed portraits, naturalism, courtly elegance.	Akbar Nama illustrations, Jahangir's flora and fauna paintings.
Deccan School	Deccan Plateau	16th–18th centuries	Fusion of Persian and Indian styles, elongated figures, vibrant colors, floral designs, and	Bijapur's Ragamala paintings, Golkonda's royal portraits.

			courtly themes.	
Bengal School	Bengal	Early 20th century	Revival of Indian traditions, use of wash techniques, themes of nationalism and spirituality.	Abanindranath Tagore's Bharat Mata, Nandalal Bose's Sati.
Tanjore School	Tamil Nadu	17th-19th centuries	Gold leaf embellishments, intricate detailing, vivid colours, and devotional themes of Hindu gods.	Paintings of Krishna, Lakshmi, and Saraswati.
Madhubani Painting	Bihar	Ancient origins, still practiced	Bright natural colours, symbolic designs, Hindu mythological themes, and floral and animal motifs.	Marriage scenes, festivals like Holi and Durga Puja.
Kalighat Painting	Bengal	19th century	Bold outlines, flat forms, satirical depictions, scenes of mythology and colonial life.	Kali and Durga depictions, critique of British officials.
Pattachitra	Odisha, West Bengal	Ancient origins, still practiced	Mythological narratives, natural dyes, intricate patterns, often on cloth or palm leaves.	Jagannath Yatra, Ramayana and Mahabharata stories.
Warli Painting	Maharashtra	Ancient origins, still practiced	Monochromatic, geometric tribal art, themes of nature, farming, and daily tribal life.	Ritualistic dance scenes, harvest festivals.
Kalamkari	Andhra Pradesh, Telangana	Ancient origins, still practiced	Hand-painted or block-printed textile art, mythological stories,	Depictions of Ramayana, Mahabharata, and

			and floral motifs.	village scenes.
Chittara Art	Karnataka	Ancient origins, still practiced	Geometric patterns on red backgrounds, inspired by tribal and rural traditions, often on walls and paper.	Scenes of village life, rituals, and nature.

Pala School of Painting

- 750 CE to the **mid-twelfth century**.
- Related to Buddhism, centres like Nalanda and Vikramsila.
- The **use of palm leaves mostly belongs to the Vajrayana School**.
- Astasahasrika Prajnaparamita ('Perfection of Wisdom')
- Characterized by sinuous lines and subdued tones of color



Apabhramsa School of Art

- The region comprises Gujarat, Rajasthan, and Malwa.
- Inspired by the ideals of Jainism.
- Mainly Patronized by the Chalukya Dynasty.
- Early one on palm leaf and then on paper.
- Reduced dimension Murals.
- Kalpasutra and Kalakacharya-Katha are popular



Modern Indian Painting

- The evolution of Modern Indian Painting is marked by several key movements and artists who brought together traditional Indian aesthetics and Western influences.

Bengal School of Art (Early 20th Century):



- It was Led by** Abanindranath Tagore and other artists such as Nandalal Bose and Rabindranath Tagore.
- This movement sought to revive traditional Indian art forms, drawing inspiration from Indian folk, Mughal, and Rajput painting styles. While rooted in indigenous techniques, Bengal School artists also experimented with Western academic techniques. The movement was a response to British colonialism, promoting a sense of national identity through art.
- Notable Works:** Abanindranath's "Bharat Mata" and Nandalal Bose's murals at the Indian Parliament Building.

Progressive Artists Group (Mid-20th Century):

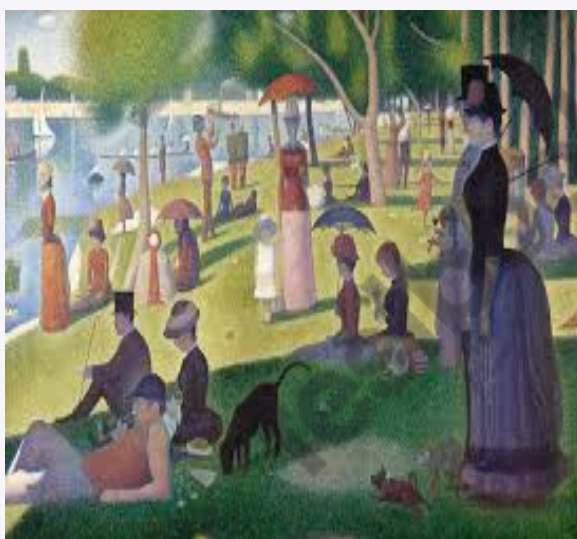
- It was Founded by** F.N. Souza, M.F. Husain, S.H. Raza, and others.
- This group, established in 1947, was a reaction against the traditionalist approach of the Bengal School. The members emphasized modernism, abstraction, and expressionism. They were influenced by European avant-garde movements like Cubism and Surrealism but sought to create



an art that was both modern and rooted in Indian culture.

- **Notable Works:** M.F. Husain's "Horses," F.N. Souza's abstract works, and S.H. Raza's "Bindu" series.

Contemporary Art (Late 20th Century to Present):



- Indian contemporary artists often explore themes of globalization, identity, and cultural heritage, blending traditional Indian motifs with global artistic trends. The use of new media, installations, and conceptual art has become common in contemporary Indian art. Artists like Anish Kapoor have gained international recognition, with Kapoor's monumental sculptures and installations exhibiting globally. Subodh Gupta's work often explores the relationship between the local and the global, using everyday objects to reflect the changing dynamics of Indian society.
- **Notable Works:** Anish Kapoor's "Cloud Gate" (Chicago), Subodh Gupta's "Very Hungry God," and Jitish Kallat's "Public Notice" series.

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